Does task-based language teaching improve speaking proficiency compared to traditional drills? (Your “dynamic context” point is untested.)

Task-based teaching improves oral fluency, while traditional drills often retain higher immediate accuracy.

Does task-based language teaching improve speaking proficiency compared to traditional drills? N = 12



Yes 92% · Possibly 0% · Mixed 0% · No 8%

The scientific literature indicates that task-based language teaching (TBLT) systematically outperforms drill-based and traditional presentation-practice-production (PPP) models in oral fluency and communicative confidence, though traditional drills frequently yield higher immediate grammatical accuracy.

FIGURE 1 Scientific consensus on task-based language teaching improving speaking proficiency compared to drills

Comparative Fluency and Accuracy Outcomes

Empirical comparisons between TBLT and structure-based frameworks highlight a clear divergence between fluency development and morphological precision (Tomita, 2025; Yu & Salem, 2024). In a randomized controlled investigation of Japanese university learners, TBLT generated superior gains in spoken fluency across immediate and delayed assessments (Tomita, 2025). However, learners instructed via traditional presentation-practice-production drills outperformed the TBLT cohort on grammatical accuracy measures on both immediate and one-week delayed tests (Tomita, 2025).

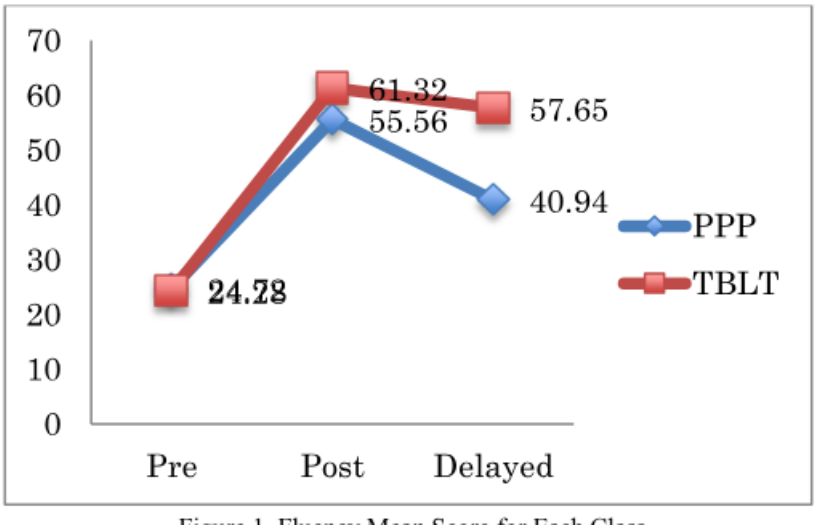


Figure 1. Fluency Mean Score for Each Class (Tomita, 2025)
How to read: The plot displays oral fluency mean scores across pretest, posttest, and delayed posttest for the two instructional cohorts. Higher values indicate greater oral fluency.

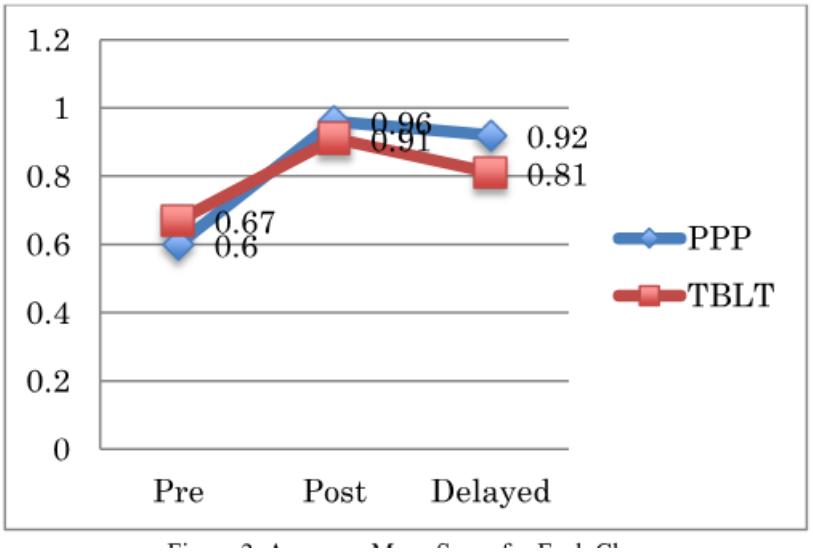


Figure 2. Accuracy Mean Score for Each Class (Tomita, 2025)
How to read: The plot illustrates grammatical accuracy mean scores across pretest, posttest, and delayed posttest for the two instructional conditions. Higher values indicate fewer grammatical errors.

This trade-off is mirrored across broader classroom interventions comparing task-supported curricula to conventional drill or translation methods (Nguyen, 2026; Nawaz et al., 2025; Naseer-Ud-Din et al., 2025). A 10-week quasi-experimental study of intermediate EFL learners found that task-driven practice fostered significantly higher fluency and communicative willingness, but both instructional models resulted in comparable average accuracy levels (Nawaz et al., 2025). Similarly, primary school pupils instructed in Malay through TBLT exhibited statistically significant improvements in oral fluency over conventional drill-and-reading controls, whereas post-test differences for vocabulary range and structural grammar were not statistically significant between groups (Omar et al., 2021).

Speaking Performance Across Diverse Contexts

Quasi-experimental evaluations across varied educational tiers document broad speaking gains when replacing rote drills with structured tasks:

- Secondary students instructed via TBLT in District Kohat achieved **significant spoken fluency gains**, with mean oral scores rising from 9.45 to 16.78 compared to modest improvements under traditional instruction (Naseer-Ud-Din et al., 2025).
- Vocational high school students taught via task-based modules reached **significantly higher post-test speaking scores** (mean 66.38) compared to peers instructed using the direct method (mean 60.30) (Lume & Hisbullah, 2022).
- Engineering undergraduates participating in task-based discussions and presentations achieved **substantially higher post-test fluency scores** (mean 6.22) relative to conventional instruction controls (mean 5.00) (Basireddi et al., 2025).
- Non-English major college students demonstrated **statistically superior overall speaking gains** in accuracy and fluency over traditional methods following an eight-week task intervention (Panduwangi, 2021).

TABLE 5
T-TEST: PAIRED TWO SAMPLE FOR MEANS IN POST-TEST FLUENCY OF EXP GRP VS CTRL GRP

t-Test: Paired Two Sample for Means in Post Test Fluency of Exp Grp Vs Ctrl Grp		
	Exp Group	Ctrl Group
	Fluency	*Fluency*
Mean	6.22	5

Table 3. The post-test fluency scores of the Experimental Group and the Control Group show a statistically significant difference, according to the t-test results. In terms of Fluency, the Experimental Group fared noticeably better than the Control Group (mean score of 5.00), with a mean score of 6.22. This suggests that, in comparison to the Control Group, the TBLT intervention significantly and favourably improved the Experimental Group's speaking fluency abilities. (Basireddi et al., 2025)
How to read: The table lists independent sample t-test results comparing oral fluency post-test scores between experimental and control groups. A p-value below 0.05 indicates a statistically significant difference.

Summary of Empirical Comparisons

Study Context & Sample	Pedagogical Comparison	Primary Fluency Outcome	Primary Accuracy & Form Outcome	Affective Impact
Japanese EFL undergraduates (N=40) (Tomita, 2025)	TBLT vs. PPP drill framework (Tomita, 2025)	TBLT produced **superior fluency gains** (Tomita, 2025)	PPP maintained **higher grammatical accuracy** (Tomita, 2025)	Not evaluated (Tomita, 2025)
Indonesian EFL college learners (N=60) (Panduwangi, 2021)	TBLT vs. conventional instruction (Panduwangi, 2021)	Significant improvement in **oral fluency** (Panduwangi, 2021)	Parallel gains in **lexical accuracy** (Panduwangi, 2021)	Boosted **speaking self-confidence** (Panduwangi, 2021)
Singaporean primary pupils (N=52) (Omar et al., 2021)	TBLT vs. conventional PPP package (Omar et al., 2021)	Significant group advantage for **speech fluency** (Omar et al., 2021)	**No significant difference** in language structure (Omar et al., 2021)	Increased **motivation and confidence** (Omar et al., 2021)
Vietnamese hospitality majors (N=60) (Nguyen, 2023)	8-week TBLT vs. conventional teaching (Nguyen, 2023)	Marked growth in **discourse coherence** (Nguyen, 2023)	Structured attention to **target vocabulary** (Nguyen, 2023)	Favorable **learner attitudes** (Nguyen, 2023)

Study Context & Sample	Pedagogical Comparison	Primary Fluency Outcome	Primary Accuracy & Form Outcome	Affective Impact
Kurdish grade 10 students (N=72) (■ Mohamedamin, 2025)	One-semester TBLT vs. traditional drills (■ Mohamedamin, 2025)	Significant acceleration in **speech delivery** (■ Mohamedamin, 2025)	Incremental gains across **grammar metrics** (■ Mohamedamin, 2025)	Enhanced **classroom engagement** (■ Mohamedamin, 2025)

FIGURE 2 Empirical comparison of speaking outcomes between task-based language teaching and traditional instructional methods

Instructional Mechanisms and Practical Constraints

The fluency advantages of TBLT stem primarily from the procedural demands of authentic communication, which force learners to negotiate meaning and mobilize vocabulary in real time (■ Naida & Astutik, 2026; ■ Nguyen, 2023; ■ Naseer-Ud-Din et al., 2025; ■ Masuram & Sripada, 2020). Pre-task planning phases and post-task reporting requirements help students organize complex ideas, steadily reducing hesitation pauses and false starts (■ Yu & Salem, 2024; ■ Nguyen, 2023; Pham, 2025; Hasnain & Halder, 2021; ■ Masuram & Sripada, 2020). Longitudinal studies that embed systematic corrective feedback—such as recasts and prompts—into task implementation demonstrate concurrent improvements in utterance elaboration and phonological speed without abandoning form entirely (Albino, 2017; ■ Basireddi et al., 2025).

Nevertheless, TBLT presents well-documented instructional trade-offs. Because meaning takes precedence over grammatical form, open-ended tasks without explicit form-focused components can fail to remediate persistent phonological or structural errors (■ Nguyen, 2026; ■ Azizifard, 2024; ■ Basireddi et al., 2025). In architectural engineering English courses, task-based oral presentations substantially improved student motivation and participation but produced no noticeable enhancement in pronunciation clarity or grammatical precision (■ Azizifard, 2024). Furthermore, the efficacy of TBLT is constrained by task design complexity, initial learner proficiency, and institutional factors such as class size, brief intervention durations, and traditional grammar-based testing regimes (■ Naida & Astutik, 2026; ■ Nawaz et al., 2025; ■ Yu & Salem, 2024; Waluyo & Wangdi, 2024; ■ Naseer-Ud-Din et al., 2025).

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